UINATION

against a future laced with poison



KISS OF THE THORN Bhetavada sarpanch Panna Vaghela and (top right) a house abandoned after a deluge of toxic rainwater in August

Photographs by MAYUR BHATT



gets camouflaged. Multiple representations to local politicians, state ministers, collectors, municipal authorities and pollution control officials went in vain. That finally sowed the seeds of protest.

For over a month now, hundreds of villagers—men, women, children—have been gathering every day at a site that sits just meters away from one of the companies accused of the chemical discharge. Collectivised, their anger is now finally being heard, seen and felt, and they will settle for nothing short of a decisive solution. As exhibits, they show deformed fingers and rashes that never fully heal; several women in their twenties show bald patches. Panna Vaghela, the woman sarpanch of Bhetavada, says over 50 villagers have died of cancer in recent years and over 20 are in treatment. "The contaminated water has seeped into the water table," she says. "We're forced to bathe in it. For drinking water, we have all paid for RO."

Walking through Bhetavada, the smell hits first, a chemical sourness catches the throat and forces visitors to cover their noses. "We live here. We have nowhere to go," Panna says. Houses stand a few feet from the canals where the frothing sludge keeps up a near-constant flow. Officials tried to talk protesters down, in late August, and failed. They say they stood down several times before, accepting promises from the same officials and local MLAs, but the problem always returned. This time, they say, they're staying until it's fixed.

Looks aren't deceptive. The network of drains threading through the villages were, ironically, canals dug by the state government in 2015. They were meant to bring Narmada water for irrigation. That never came, villagers say. What arrived was a river of toxins. That eventually reached the rose farms, the village's identity and primary source of income. With no Narmada water, the village used ground water for irrigation—for the past three years, Panna says, the crop has completely failed.

Takeaways

- **Bhetavada, once a supplier of roses to Ahmedabad, now battles a rising cancer count**
- **A network of canals, meant to bring Narmada water, gets Dholka's toxic sewage instead**
- **Pharma units in the vicinity draw villagers' ire; as protest makes news, HC steps in**

WHOSE POISON IS IT?

A senior officer at the Gujarat Pollution Control Board offers a diagnosis that shifts the blame toward Dholka. "We take surprise samples every fortnight. What we find consistently is a high volume of fecal coliform. Chemical discharge is negligible by comparison," he says. The only measure of that, for now, is the cancer count. What he points to is a gaping hole. Dholka's discharge runs to 20 mld; its sewage treatment plant (STP) is rated for 13.5 mld. "Even that isn't fully operational. So below 10 per cent gets treated," he says.

Even old parts of town were never fully connected to an end-to-end drainage network. Now a burst of unplanned urbanisation has added to the mess. The town is planning a 20-mld STP. Its first one took six years to make, but now there's an urgency. The Gujarat High Court has joined the vigil, converting a 2018 PIL into a suo motu case. On August 21, Chief Justice Sunita Agarwal and Justice Vaibhavi Nanavati berated Dholka Nagarpalika for its "complete inaction" and "complete ignorance", ordering an expert study. The villagers say the protest ends when the toxic water does. ■